

# SPORTSTAR OF THE YEAR



**Star honour:** ICC chairman Jay Shah presented the Sportstar of the Year (Female) award to double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker. R. V. MOORTHY

helpful. And sometimes, I really need that help. The downside is I tend to have long conversations. Some turn out to be very long, and I miss commitments," she laughs. Manu had come agonisingly close to another bronze medal in the 25m sports pistol. When the curtains fell on the 'Rapid' qualification round, only Veronika Major of Hungary had a better score than Manu. It was Major again who edged out the

Indian in a shoot-off for bronze in the final, registering an extra hit (10.2-plus shot).

When asked how much she would hypothetically pay to retake the deciding shot, she smiles wryly before saying, "I am a very practical person, and I know that no amount of money or anything else can take me back in time. So, I'm just going to focus on the present and work towards better results in the future."

It is difficult to miss Manu in a crowd. Selfie and autograph hunters are drawn to her like moths to a flame. Yet, the Jhajjar-born athlete obliges everyone without hesitation.

"Honestly, I try to accommodate

every request. Sometimes it gets really difficult, but I do my best," she says.

Just when one begins to appreciate the maturity beyond her years, a remark serves as a fleeting reminder of how young she actually is. "I try to enjoy every moment because YOLO (you only live once)," the 22-year-old (at the time of the interview) says, explaining how she is balancing her newfound fame while preparing to return to competition after an extended break.

"Yes, it was a little difficult to manage all the travelling. But getting back to training? Not so